
What Daniel Naroditsky's Death Reveals About the Chess World's Dark Side

Published by

Owen Poindexter

Estimated reading time

10 min

Added on

2025-11-03

Address

<https://slate.com/technology/2025/11/daniel-naroditsky-death-chess-grandmaster-vladimir-kramnik-twitch-stream.html>

What Daniel Naroditsky's Death Reveals About the Chess World's Dark Side

In his last Twitch stream, three days before his death at age 29 on Oct. 19, chess grandmaster Daniel Naroditsky was typically thoughtful and articulate—but there seemed to be something bothering him.

“There’s a particular kind of comment that people from time to time express, which is always well intentioned. People who express this opinion are always doing it from a place of love,” he began, referring to a comment he had just seen on Reddit. “But I have an irrational, burning hatred of this opinion, which is based on complete and shocking ignorance of the situation. I really shouldn’t charge people with the crime of ignorance, and let it slide, but it can be hard sometimes.”

For the past year, Naroditsky had been tormented by his childhood hero, former world champion Vladimir Kramnik, who insisted that Naroditsky was cheating while he played online. Chess computers (or “engines”) have been better at the ancient game than any human for more than two decades, and now many high-level engines are publicly available. Cheating in online games is easy enough. In slower games, players can simultaneously play their opponent’s moves against a computer in a separate window, and software exists to show computer-recommended moves overlaid on one’s own games, which saves needed time in faster formats. Algorithms on popular platforms like Chess.com and Lichess.org will quickly catch players making excessive use of engines, but employing them selectively can give cheaters a decisive and likely undetectable advantage.

The comment that got under Naroditsky’s skin, however, was not another echo of Kramnik’s accusations. Rather it was a supporter saying that he should just brush the whole thing off. Naroditsky, measuring out his frustrated words while dueling other grandmasters on Chess.com in three-minute blitz games, explained that the number of people who believed Kramnik, while a minority, was “catastrophically, existentially high to the point where this is an imminent and incredibly sticky threat to my career.”

He detailed the rationale behind his reputation-defending actions as if explaining the theory behind a chess move while he traded victories with similarly strong players. “Don’t let the people saying ‘Don’t let it get to you’ get to you,” he chuckled at one point.

No cause of death has been announced. North Carolina’s Charlotte-Mecklenburg Police Department is investigating it as a possible overdose or suicide. Much of the chess community is pointing the blame for Naroditsky’s passing squarely at Kramnik, who has since been banned for life by Chess.com, due to his persistent bullying, often based on flimsy evidence, of Naroditsky and many others. Kramnik has denied any responsibility for Naroditsky’s death and even claims he never actually accused Naroditsky of cheating—rather, he claims that he was merely asking reasonable questions about his performance. That may be literally true, but it is difficult to watch Kramnik’s numerous videos on Naroditsky’s play, analysis, eye movements, and the like without concluding that Kramnik is implying that Naroditsky is cheating. Kramnik has also filed a complaint with the Geneva public prosecutor regarding “hundreds of terrifying private messages and public comments” he has received since Naroditsky’s death.

In chess, a teacher can explain their moves—something Naroditsky was arguably the best at among YouTube creators—but even if the student doesn’t understand, the proof is in the result of the game.

In the court of online commenters and murmurs among fellow players, there is no such final arbiter.

“It wasn’t just Kramnik,” Dina Belenkaya, who holds the title of woman grandmaster and is a fellow streamer, told Slate. “It was all these other people who Danya was really looking up to, and they were all kind of his heroes, and they all turned against him.”

That a former world champion like Kramnik was able to stir up agreement among some social media and message-board posters isn’t surprising. More perplexing is that he was able to do so among some of the game’s top players, who at least played footsie with the notion that Naroditsky cheated, despite speculative-at-best reasoning. The accuser’s key points included that Naroditsky sometimes looked to the side while he was thinking (Kramnik presumably thought he was peeking at a second monitor) and he seized on a certain move that Naroditsky said was “interesting” before opting for another, saying that no human would ever consider that move, which turned out to be the second choice of the engine. Grandmaster Ian Nepomniachitchi [posted](#) on X that he and his team couldn’t “explain” the move that Kramnik found suspicious.

“Very few top players actually respect what streamers do,” Belenkaya, who believes there was motivated reasoning behind some of the suspicions, explained. “People were also jealous that he was popular, that people loved him.”

Danya, as Naroditsky was often called, set up multiple cameras to show his setup while he played, and found numerous instances of top players making a move similar to the one that Kramnik highlighted. But it did little to dissuade those who thought he was getting illicit help, and it rankled him that those efforts weren’t appreciated more by certain people.

“My mind goes to how he must have been feeling as the object of public humiliation in a community that he values so much and in a community that his self-worth and self-esteem are tied to,” psychologist Michael Stanton, of California State University, East Bay, told Slate. “The fact that the bully was someone that he held in such high regard makes it so much worse.”

While we don’t know the cause of Naroditsky’s death, the context surrounding it has many speculating that it was the result of self-harm and suicide. According to Stanton, cyberbullying is associated with higher rates of self-harm than in-person bullying because it is not bound by a particular time or place. “The most consistent way that we, in a laboratory, induce stress is through something that’s unpredictable, social, and inescapable, which is exactly what cyberbullying is,” Stanton explained. “I almost can’t think of a worse psychological stressor than being bullied by a community that you value.”

That community is now amid a reckoning. “What’s happening right now is really putting a spotlight on the consequences for people who might be revered in one part of chess and think that they can make accusations or speak freely without consequences in another arena,” Danny Rensch, chief chess officer for Chess.com, told Slate, “and they’re learning that they really can’t and never really should have.”

In addition to fury at Kramnik, many in the chess community are directing their attention toward the sport’s governing body, FIDE, which is now reviewing Kramnik’s statements for potential disciplinary action. For some, this is too little, too late from an organization with a [history of alleged corruption](#) and reports alleging that it is acting as an extension of the Russian government. The bulk of those complaints came under FIDE president Kirsan Ilyumzhinov, who was also a Russian politician. Reforms under Arkady Dvorkovich (another Russian politician), who replaced Ilyumzhinov

in 2018, have quieted many of those voices, but for some, the history still lingers. A [petition](#) calling for FIDE to ban Kramnik from all FIDE-sponsored tournaments and revoke his titles has more than 47,000 signatures. Woman grandmaster Nemo Zhou has [called](#) for a boycott of FIDE by players and sponsors until action is taken.

“Danya Naroditsky is not the only person who’s been accused, and there are other people who have also been calling for FIDE to take action,” Rensch said. “I hope that this is something that actually wakes them up. They are the governance that the chess world has. They are not the governance that I believe the chess world deserves, and I hope that we have better days ahead.”

Cheating accusations test the power of the accuser and the resilience of the accused. They can vanish quickly, linger, or, when certain toxic dynamics come together, end a career. Magnus Carlsen’s accusation against Hans Niemann in 2022 became a national story through a mix of factors including Carlsen’s stature as the world’s best player and [the mystery of if and how Niemann did it](#), which inspired statistical analyses and endless social media fodder. (There were no mea culpas, but after a lifted ban from Chess.com and a settled lawsuit, Niemann is back to playing at the highest levels.) Others, such as Nepomniachtchi’s [accusation](#) against current world champion Gukesh Dommaraju (prior to him winning the title), barely caused a stir.

What few want to acknowledge at the moment is that the chess world has sometimes leaned into scandal—it’s good for ratings, after all. A Kramnik tweet from May 2024 casting suspicion on a dozen players, including Naroditsky, resulted in the [return of suicidal ideation](#) for David Navara, one of the players mentioned. It also inspired two cash-prize matches between Kramnik and another of his accused, José Martínez, titled “Clash of Claims” and “Clash of Blames.” Martínez won the first match—a result that Kramnik blamed on technical difficulties during the online portion. Kramnik narrowly won the rematch. No serious analyst would say that either result proves anything regarding either player’s integrity, but all parties involved seemed happy to have the buzz, including Chess.com, which produced a half-hour [documentary](#) on the first match.

As Naroditsky’s last stream progressed, he dropped the Kramnik discussion for feisty commentary on his games. Later, he started to nod off to sleep as time dripped off his game clock, which he would later chalk up to taking a Benadryl. Instead of quitting for the night, he dug in, growing ever more frustrated with his play, convinced that he could will himself into dominating his opponents. At around 1 a.m. Eastern time, following a well-crafted victory, someone off-camera told him to end the stream.

Related From Slate



[Nitish Pahwa](#)

[The World's Greatest Chess Player's Stunning Defeat, Explained](#)

[Read More](#)

It was then, in a moment that has echoed across social media, that Danya described the inescapable trap he found himself in.

“The problem is, ever since the Kramnik stuff, I feel like if I start doing well, people assume the worst of intentions. Like, ‘Why did he end the stream? He suddenly started playing well.’ You know what I mean?”

The world of online chess made Naroditsky. It fed his compulsive desire to play, particularly in the fast formats at which he excelled, and gave him a platform to unfurl his layered understanding of the game. His rising stature, however, exposed him to the darker elements of life on the internet: cynical attitudes, nihilistic teardowns, simplistic posts willingly ignorant of nuance and context—the antithesis of everything he seemed to live by. Naroditsky had strong social ties, and was well respected publicly and privately, but the thin daggers of cyberbullying may have slipped past those defenses. The reasons our perpetually online world needs people like Naroditsky are the same ones that people like him can be torn apart by it.

Before he signed off, he addressed his audience one last time: “Thanks for all the support through thick and thin. I will play a few more games, try to get that rating back up, and we’ll take it from there. Thanks, everybody. Be well, be healthy, be safe.”

He would play the last of his 140,646 games on Chess.com four hours later against Nihal Sarin, another grandmaster who has been accused of cheating by Vladimir Kramnik.

If you need to talk, or if you or someone you know is experiencing suicidal thoughts, call the [988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline](#) or chat at [988lifeline.org](#).

Get the best of news and politics

Sign up for Slate's evening newsletter.

Thanks for signing up! You can [manage your newsletter subscriptions](#) at any time.

You're already subscribed to the The Slatest newsletter. You can [manage your newsletter subscriptions](#) at any time.

We encountered an issue signing you up. Please try again, or [manage all your newsletter subscriptions here](#) .

Please enable javascript to sign up for newsletters.

Email address:

Send me updates about Slate special offers.

By signing up, you agree to our [Privacy Policy](#) and [Terms](#).

Sign Up

Produced by wallabag with tcpdf

Please open [an issue](#) if you have trouble with the display of this E-Book on your device.